



Customer Discovery Operations Manual

Version 1.0

The Covenant answers why. This Manual answers how.

This Manual governs how LifeBook conducts customer discovery. It describes procedures, workflows, responsibilities, and standards for every stage of the discovery process — from recruiting a participant to retiring evidence.

This Manual does not describe why these procedures exist. That is the purpose of the Interviewer Covenant, which should be read and signed before engaging with any section of this document. Every procedural decision in this Manual is downstream of the principles in the Covenant.

The Covenant answers why. This Manual answers how. When they appear to conflict, the Covenant governs.

01 SCOPE AND PURPOSE

This Manual applies to all LifeBook customer discovery activity. It covers calibration interviews, evidence-generating interviews, synthesis sessions, and all associated documentation. It applies to all interviewers, note-takers, and anyone who participates in or reviews discovery sessions.

The purpose of customer discovery at LifeBook is to develop a truthful, evidence-based understanding of the people LifeBook serves — their behaviours, motivations, unmet needs, and relationship to the act of preserving their lives. Discovery is not a validation exercise. It is an inquiry.

TERM	DEFINITION
Calibration Interview	An interview conducted for interviewer development. Data from calibration interviews is not entered into the Evidence Registry.
Evidence-Generating Interview	An interview conducted by a certified interviewer whose output may be coded and entered into the Evidence Registry.
Certification Authority (CA)	The person responsible for reviewing calibration recordings and certifying interviewers. Defined in section 08.
Evidence Registry	The central repository for coded interview evidence. Defined in section 17.
Hypothesis Registry	The register of active hypotheses against which evidence is

	evaluated. Defined in section 03.
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02 PARTICIPANT SCREENING AND RECRUITMENT

Participant recruitment determines whose experiences enter the evidence base. Poorly targeted recruitment produces evidence that is structurally misleading — not because the interviews are conducted badly, but because the participants do not represent the population LifeBook needs to understand.

Recruit for diversity of experience, not for likelihood of validation.

For each recruitment cycle, the Certification Authority approves a participant profile before outreach begins. The profile specifies the demographic and experiential criteria the cohort should collectively represent — not criteria designed to select participants who are likely to respond positively to LifeBook.

02 SCREENING CRITERIA

Screening criteria should be defined at the cohort level, not the individual level. The goal is a cohort that collectively reflects meaningful variation in the following dimensions:

- ▶ Age and life stage (not limited to older participants)
- ▶ Prior experience with memory preservation, legacy planning, or family history
- ▶ Comfort with digital tools and services
- ▶ Family structure and proximity to loss or major life transition
- ▶ No prior knowledge of LifeBook (required for at least 25% of each cohort)

Important: *Participants who express enthusiasm for LifeBook during screening should not be preferentially recruited. Enthusiasm in screening is not evidence of product-market fit.*

02 OUTREACH AND SCHEDULING

1. Identify candidate participants using the approved profile. Document the source of each candidate (referral, social, network, etc.).
2. Send the initial outreach message. Do not describe LifeBook in marketing terms. Describe it as "a project about how people preserve and share their lives and memories."
3. Screen candidates using the screening questions approved for the current cohort. Record responses. Do not share screening results with candidates.
4. Schedule confirmed participants. Send calendar invite with Zoom link, consent form link, and plain-language session description.
5. Log participant in the Participant Registry (section 17) with status: Scheduled.

03 HYPOTHESIS REGISTRY

The Hypothesis Registry is the authoritative record of what LifeBook currently believes to be true about its participants, their needs, and the opportunity it is pursuing. Every hypothesis in the Registry is an explicit claim that discovery is either testing or refining.

An undocumented assumption is not a hypothesis. It is a bias waiting to become a conclusion.

Before each discovery cycle, the Certification Authority reviews and updates the Hypothesis Registry. Hypotheses are added when new assumptions are identified. Hypotheses are closed — not deleted — when sufficient evidence has accumulated to treat them as confirmed, refuted, or retired.

FIELD	DESCRIPTION
Hypothesis ID	Sequential identifier (H-001, H-002, etc.)
Statement	The specific claim being tested, written as a falsifiable assertion
Category	Customer (who they are), Problem (what they need), Solution (whether LifeBook addresses it)
Status	Active / Confirmed / Refuted / Retired
Evidence IDs	Coded evidence entries that bear on this hypothesis
Opened	Date the hypothesis was added to the Registry
Closed	Date and disposition when the hypothesis was closed

Hypotheses must be written as falsifiable assertions. "People value their memories" is not a hypothesis. "People who have experienced significant loss are more likely to initiate memory preservation activity within 12 months of that loss" is a hypothesis.

Important: Interviewers should not be shown the full Hypothesis Registry before an interview. Knowledge of active hypotheses increases the risk of confirmation-seeking behaviour. The CA reviews hypotheses with interviewers only in post-interview debrief.

04 INTERVIEW PREPARATION

Preparation is the interviewer's primary protection against in-session bias. An unprepared interviewer fills silence with improvisation, and improvisation is where leading questions are born.

04 INTERVIEW GUIDE

The Interview Guide is the approved question set for a given discovery cycle. It is maintained by the CA and reviewed before each cohort. The Guide is not a script — it is a map. The interviewer may move through it non-linearly, skip questions that are naturally answered, and follow threads the participant opens.

The Guide contains three types of questions:

- ▶ Opening questions — broad, behaviourally anchored, designed to establish context and participant comfort
- ▶ Core questions — the primary inquiry for the current cycle, directly related to active hypotheses (without naming them)
- ▶ Closing questions — forward-looking, designed to surface what the participant values and what they wish existed

Important: Questions that reference LifeBook by name or that describe its features are not permitted in the Interview Guide. LifeBook should not be introduced until the closing phase, and only if the protocol for the current cycle permits it.

04 PRE-INTERVIEW CHECKLIST

1. Review the Interview Guide for the current cycle. Read it twice — once for content, once for sequence.
 2. Review the participant's screening responses. Note anything that may be relevant context, but do not form predictions about how the interview will proceed.
 3. Prepare the observation capture template (section 11). Open it before the session begins.
 4. Confirm Zoom setup is complete (section 06). Test recording permissions.
 5. Set aside 15 minutes before the session to clear the prior task. Do not begin an interview immediately after another meeting.
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05 PARTICIPANT ONBOARDING AND CONSENT

Participant onboarding establishes the conditions under which the interview will be conducted. It is not a formality. The consent process is the participant's first experience of LifeBook's values in practice.

05 CONSENT FORM

The consent form is sent to participants before the session. It describes, in plain language: the purpose of the session, how the recording will be used, how data will be stored and protected, the participant's right to withdraw at any point, and whether their name will be associated with any of their responses.

The consent form is not a legal instrument designed to protect LifeBook. It is an honest description of what the participant is agreeing to. If a participant asks a question about the consent form that the form does not answer, the answer must be honest and must be recorded in the session log.

LifeBook does not use participant names in published research, internal presentations, or evidence documentation without explicit, named consent.

05 SESSION OPENING

1. Confirm the participant has received and reviewed the consent form. Ask if they have any questions before proceeding.
 2. Confirm verbal consent to recording. Do not proceed without it. If the participant declines recording, the session may proceed without recording — but note-taking must be more rigorous and the absence of a recording must be logged.
 3. Describe the session in plain terms: "This is a conversation, not a test. There are no right answers. I'm here to listen and learn — your honest reaction to anything is exactly what I'm looking for."
 4. Invite the participant to ask questions before beginning. Answer honestly. If a question cannot be answered without biasing the interview, say so plainly: "I'd rather come back to that at the end so it doesn't shape where we start — is that okay?"
 5. Begin recording. Confirm aloud that recording has started.
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06 ZOOM SETUP AND RECORDING

All evidence-generating interviews are conducted over Zoom and recorded. Calibration interviews are also recorded — recordings are required for certification review.

06 ZOOM CONFIGURATION

SETTING	REQUIRED CONFIGURATION
Recording	Local recording enabled. Cloud recording as backup if local fails.
Recording consent	Zoom consent prompt enabled — do not disable. Verbal consent is required in addition.
Video	Interviewer camera on. Participant camera optional — never required.
Waiting room	Enabled. Admit participant manually after confirming readiness.
Chat	Disabled during session to avoid distraction.
Transcription	Auto-transcription enabled if Zoom plan permits. Not a substitute for manual transcription review (section 13).

06 RECORDING MANAGEMENT

1. Name the recording file immediately after the session: LB-[YYYYMMDD]-[Participant ID]-[Interviewer initials]. Example: LB-20260301-P017-TD.
2. Upload recording to the secure storage location within 24 hours of the session. Do not store recordings locally beyond 48 hours.
3. Log the recording location in the Participant Registry entry for this session.
4. Do not share recording links outside the LifeBook discovery team without CA approval.

Important: *If a recording fails to capture, the session is not invalidated. Note the recording failure in the session log, conduct the debrief from notes, and flag the session in the Evidence Registry as "unrecorded" if it proceeds to evidence extraction.*

07 CALIBRATION PROTOCOL

Calibration is the process by which a new interviewer develops the discipline described in the Interviewer Covenant before their interviews are treated as evidence. Calibration interviews are conducted on the same schedule and with the same care as evidence-generating interviews. They differ only in how their output is classified.

Calibration is not practice. It is proof.

The minimum calibration requirement is four interviews before certification review. There is no maximum — calibration continues until the CA determines that the interviewer meets all four certification criteria. An interviewer who does not meet the criteria after four interviews continues calibrating. An interviewer who meets them in four proceeds to certification review.

07 CALIBRATION SESSION PROCEDURE

1. All calibration sessions are recorded. No exceptions.
2. After each calibration session, the interviewer completes the Post-Interview Observation Form (section 11) without reviewing the recording first.
3. The interviewer submits the recording and Observation Form to the CA within 24 hours.

4. The CA reviews the recording against the four certification criteria and returns written feedback within 72 hours.
5. The CA and interviewer conduct a debrief session — minimum 30 minutes — for each calibration recording reviewed.
6. Debrief notes are logged in the Calibration Record for this interviewer.

Calibration debrief is not a performance review. It is a collaborative examination of what happened in the room — what the interviewer observed, what patterns emerged, and where the Covenant's principles were tested.

08 INTERVIEWER CERTIFICATION

Certification is the CA's determination that an interviewer is ready to conduct evidence-generating interviews. It is based on the four criteria defined in the Interviewer Covenant. Certification is not automatic, and it is not permanent.

08 CERTIFICATION CRITERIA

Certification requires that all four of the following criteria are met, as determined by the CA:

- ▶ Recorded calibration interviews demonstrate no systematic pattern of leading questions, verified through recording review.
- ▶ Conversations in calibration recordings demonstrate that the participant, not the interviewer, determines the direction of the conversation.
- ▶ At least one calibration interview has been conducted with a participant who has no prior knowledge of LifeBook.
- ▶ In a formal debrief, the interviewer demonstrates the ability to articulate what was observed separately from what was interpreted — without conflating the two.

08 CERTIFICATION AUTHORITY

The Certification Authority is responsible for reviewing calibration recordings, providing debrief feedback, and making certification determinations. The CA may not certify themselves. When a

new CA is appointed, certification of the incoming CA must be conducted by the outgoing CA or an external reviewer who meets equivalent standards.

The CA maintains a Calibration Record for each interviewer that documents: all calibration sessions reviewed, feedback provided, criteria met and unmet, and the date and basis of certification.

08 DECERTIFICATION

Certification may be suspended if a certified interviewer's evidence-generating interviews show patterns inconsistent with the Covenant's principles. The CA may require additional calibration sessions before reinstating certification. Decertification is a quality assurance measure, not a disciplinary one.

09 INTERVIEW WORKFLOW

This section describes the standard workflow for an evidence-generating interview from session open to file close. Calibration interviews follow the same workflow; their output is handled differently at the evidence extraction stage.

PHASE	DURATION	DESCRIPTION
Preparation	15 min before	Pre-interview checklist complete. Recording tested. Observation template open.
Onboarding	5–10 min	Consent confirmed. Recording started. Session framed.
Opening	10–15 min	Broad, behaviourally anchored questions. Participant context established.
Core	25–35 min	Primary inquiry. Guide followed non-linearly as conversation develops.
Closing	10 min	Forward-looking questions. LifeBook introduction if protocol permits.
Debrief capture	Immediately after	Observation Form completed before reviewing recording or notes.
File close	Within 24	Recording uploaded. Session logged. Observation Form

	hrs	submitted to CA.
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Total target session length: 55–65 minutes. Sessions shorter than 45 minutes should be flagged in the session log with a note on why the session ended early.

10 INTERVIEWER CONDUCT

The following conduct standards apply in every session. They are operational expressions of the principles in the Interviewer Covenant. Where a conduct standard and a Covenant principle appear to conflict, the Covenant governs.

10 LANGUAGE

- ▶ Ask one question at a time. Compound questions give participants permission to answer the easier of the two.
- ▶ Use the participant's language, not LifeBook's. If a participant says "photo album," the interviewer says "photo album" — not "memory preservation artifact."
- ▶ Do not use the word "interesting." It signals that a particular answer was unexpected or noteworthy, which teaches the participant what to say next.
- ▶ Do not paraphrase a participant's answer before asking a follow-up. Paraphrase is interpretation presented as summary. Ask what they said, not what you understood.

10 SILENCE AND PACING

- ▶ Wait at least five seconds after a participant finishes speaking before responding. Count silently if necessary.
- ▶ Do not rephrase a question because the participant hesitates. Hesitation is thinking. Let it happen.
- ▶ When a participant trails off or pauses mid-thought, say nothing. The silence belongs to them.

10 RESPONSES TO CRITICISM AND CONFUSION

- ▶ If a participant misunderstands LifeBook, do not correct them. Say: "Tell me more about what you're imagining." The misunderstanding is information.
- ▶ If a participant criticizes LifeBook, do not defend it. Say: "That's helpful — can you say more about that?" Then stop talking.
- ▶ If a participant asks whether LifeBook is a real product, answer honestly. Do not fabricate features or timelines.

11 OBSERVATION CAPTURE

Observation capture is the process of recording what happened in a session — separate from what it means. This distinction is the operational expression of Covenant Principle VI: Observe First. Interpret Later.

What a participant says is an observation. What it means is an interpretation. Capture them separately.

The Post-Interview Observation Form is completed immediately after each session — before reviewing the recording, before reviewing notes, and before discussing the session with anyone else. Its purpose is to capture the interviewer's uncontaminated recollection.

11 POST-INTERVIEW OBSERVATION FORM

FIELD	INSTRUCTIONS
Session ID	Auto-populated from Participant Registry
Interviewer	Name and certification status
Date / Time	Session start time and duration
Opening observations	What the participant said, in their words, in the first 15 minutes. No interpretation.
Moments of emphasis	Any moment where the participant showed strong emotion, repeated a point, or changed energy. Describe the behaviour — not the cause.
Silences	Note any extended silences (5+ seconds). What preceded and followed them.

Contradictions	Any point where the participant said something that appeared to contradict something said earlier. Do not resolve the contradiction — record it.
Unexpected content	Anything said that the interviewer did not anticipate. No interpretation.
Closing observations	What the participant said in the final 15 minutes. Include their reaction to LifeBook if introduced.
Interviewer state	Brief honest note on the interviewer's own state during the session — fatigue, distraction, emotional response to content.

Important: *The Observation Form is not a summary of the session. It is a record of what was observed. Interpretations, hypotheses, and implications belong in the Evidence Extraction step (section 12) — not here.*

12 EVIDENCE EXTRACTION

Evidence extraction is the process of reviewing a completed session — recording, transcript, and Observation Form — and identifying specific statements or behaviours that bear on one or more active hypotheses. Evidence extraction is conducted by the interviewer and reviewed by the CA before entry into the Evidence Registry.

Evidence extraction occurs after the Observation Form is complete and the recording has been reviewed at least once. The interviewer must have completed the Observation Form before reviewing the recording — this sequence is mandatory.

12 EVIDENCE ENTRY FORMAT

FIELD	INSTRUCTIONS
Evidence ID	Sequential identifier (E-001, E-002, etc.)
Session ID	Linked to Participant Registry
Hypothesis IDs	One or more hypotheses this evidence bears on
Observation	Direct quote or precise behavioural description. No paraphrase.
Timestamp	Recording timestamp for the quoted statement

Direction	Supports / Refutes / Ambiguous — relative to the linked hypothesis
Interpretation	The interviewer's assessment of what this observation means, clearly labelled as interpretation
CA review	CA approval or revision notes before Registry entry

Evidence entries that conflate observation and interpretation will be returned for revision before Registry entry. This is not a quality failure — it is the process working.

13 TRANSCRIPTION

Transcription converts session recordings into searchable text. Transcripts are used in evidence extraction, coding, and synthesis. They are not the primary source of evidence — the recording is. When a transcript and recording disagree, the recording governs.

13 TRANSCRIPTION STANDARDS

1. Use Zoom auto-transcription or an approved transcription service. Do not use publicly-accessible AI transcription tools with participant audio without consent.
2. Review the auto-transcript against the recording. Correct speaker labels, misheard words, and missing content. Flag sections where audio quality made accurate transcription impossible.
3. Remove participant names from the transcript. Replace with [P] for participant and [I] for interviewer. Retain the participant's Participant ID in the file header.
4. Store the corrected transcript in the same secure location as the recording. Name it identically, with the extension -TRANSCRIPT.
5. Log transcript completion in the Participant Registry.

Note: Transcripts contain personally identifiable information even after name removal. Treat them with the same data handling standards as the recordings (section 19).

14 CODING METHODOLOGY

Coding is the process of tagging evidence entries with categories that allow patterns to emerge across sessions. The coding scheme is maintained by the CA and updated at the start of each discovery cycle.

14 CODE CATEGORIES

The primary coding dimensions are:

DIMENSION	DESCRIPTION	EXAMPLES
Behaviour	What the participant does	"backs up photos monthly," "hasn't written anything down"
Motivation	Why they do it	"worried family will forget," "doesn't think about it"
Friction	What gets in the way	"too time-consuming," "doesn't know where to start"
Emotion	How they feel about it	"guilty," "overwhelmed," "peaceful"
Trigger	What prompted the behaviour or reflection	"parent died," "child was born," "moved house"
Aspiration	What they wish they could do or have	"something my grandchildren could actually read"

Each evidence entry may receive multiple codes across multiple dimensions. Codes are applied by the interviewer and reviewed by the CA. When the CA and interviewer disagree on a code, the disagreement is documented rather than resolved by seniority. Disagreements are reviewed in the weekly synthesis session (section 16).

15 BIAS AUDITING

Bias auditing is the systematic review of evidence collection and coding for patterns that suggest the discovery process is producing confirmation rather than truth. It is conducted by the CA at the end of each discovery cycle and whenever the evidence base appears unusually consistent.

Evidence that all points the same direction is more likely evidence of a biased process than evidence of a confirmed hypothesis.

15 AUDIT TRIGGERS

A bias audit is triggered when any of the following conditions occur:

- ▶ More than 80% of evidence entries for a given hypothesis are coded as "Supports"
- ▶ Fewer than 15% of evidence entries across all hypotheses are coded as "Refutes" or "Ambiguous"
- ▶ An interviewer's Observation Forms consistently omit contradictions and moments of emphasis
- ▶ The weekly synthesis (section 16) produces conclusions that closely match the existing Hypothesis Registry without surfacing new questions

15 AUDIT PROCEDURE

1. The CA selects a random sample of 20% of evidence entries from the current cycle for independent review.
2. The CA re-codes the sampled entries without reference to the original coding.
3. The CA compares re-coded entries to original entries. Discrepancies of more than 25% in direction coding indicate a potential systematic bias.
4. If bias is identified, the CA documents the nature and probable source of the bias and determines whether affected evidence entries must be reclassified or retired.
5. Audit findings and outcomes are logged in the Evidence Registry and reported to the LifeBook leadership team.

16 WEEKLY SYNTHESIS

The weekly synthesis session is a structured review of all evidence collected in the preceding week. Its purpose is to identify emerging patterns, update hypothesis status, and generate new questions for the next discovery cycle. It is not a presentation of findings — it is an inquiry.

16 SYNTHESIS SESSION PROTOCOL

1. The CA prepares a synthesis brief before the session: new evidence entries logged since the last synthesis, hypothesis status updates, and open coding disagreements.
2. The session begins with a review of what was observed — raw evidence, uninterpreted. Participants read evidence entries aloud before discussing them.
3. The group discusses patterns: which hypotheses are accumulating evidence, which are stalled, which have new refuting evidence.
4. Open coding disagreements are resolved or documented as unresolved. Unresolved disagreements are added to the Hypothesis Registry as questions.
5. The group identifies the three most important unanswered questions that the current evidence base cannot answer. These questions inform the next cycle's Interview Guide.
6. The CA documents synthesis outcomes in the Evidence Registry. Hypothesis statuses are updated.

Synthesis is not a meeting where conclusions are reached. It is a meeting where questions are sharpened.

17 EVIDENCE MANAGEMENT

The Evidence Registry is the single source of truth for all coded discovery evidence. The Participant Registry is the single source of truth for all participant records. These are separate documents with separate access controls.

17 EVIDENCE REGISTRY

The Evidence Registry contains all approved evidence entries (section 12), their codes (section 14), and their status. It is maintained by the CA. Access is limited to the CA and certified interviewers.

The Evidence Registry does not contain participant names, contact information, or any information that could identify a participant. Evidence entries reference Participant IDs only.

17 PARTICIPANT REGISTRY

The Participant Registry contains participant contact information, session dates, consent records, recording locations, and transcript locations. It is maintained separately from the Evidence Registry with restricted access.

REGISTRY	CONTAINS	ACCESS
Evidence Registry	Coded evidence entries, hypothesis links, audit records	CA + certified interviewers
Participant Registry	Contact info, consent records, recording/transcript locations	CA only
Hypothesis Registry	Active and closed hypotheses, evidence links, synthesis notes	CA + certified interviewers
Calibration Record	Per-interviewer calibration history, feedback, certification status	CA only

18 ANOMALOUS INTERVIEW HANDLING

Not every session proceeds as expected. This section describes how to handle sessions that deviate from standard procedure in ways that affect evidence quality or participant welfare.

18 SESSION TERMINATION

A session must be terminated — and the recording stopped immediately — if:

- ▶ The participant becomes visibly distressed and requests to stop
- ▶ The participant discloses information suggesting they are at risk of harm
- ▶ A technical failure makes continued recording impossible and the session cannot be rescheduled

If a session is terminated early, the interviewer completes an Incident Report within two hours. The report describes what occurred, how the session was closed, and what follow-up (if any) is appropriate. The CA reviews all Incident Reports within 24 hours.

18 PARTICIPANT DISTRESS PROTOCOL

1. If a participant becomes emotionally distressed, stop the inquiry. Say: "We can pause here — or stop entirely if you'd prefer. This is entirely your choice."
2. Do not attempt to resolve or reframe the participant's distress. Do not redirect to the Interview Guide.
3. If the participant chooses to continue, allow them to set the pace. Do not return to the question that preceded the distress without the participant leading there.
4. Log the distress episode in the Observation Form and Incident Report. Note what preceded it and how it resolved. Do not interpret its cause.

18 EVIDENCE FROM ANOMALOUS SESSIONS

Evidence from an anomalous session may still be entered into the Evidence Registry if the session produced usable observations and the CA approves. Evidence entries from anomalous sessions are flagged accordingly. Sessions that were terminated early are not automatically excluded from evidence consideration.

19 PARTICIPANT PRIVACY AND DATA HANDLING

Participants entrust LifeBook with descriptions of their lives, relationships, losses, and fears. This information is not a resource. It is a responsibility.

Participant data is held in trust. It is used to understand, not to exploit.

19 DATA CLASSIFICATION

DATA TYPE	EXAMPLES	RETENTION	DISPOSAL
Participant contact info	Name, email, phone	Duration of study + 12 months	Secure deletion

Consent records	Signed consent forms	Duration of study + 24 months	Secure deletion
Recordings	Zoom video files	Duration of study + 12 months	Secure deletion
Transcripts	De-identified text	Duration of study + 12 months	Secure deletion
Evidence entries	Coded, de-identified	Indefinite (part of research record)	N/A

19 DATA STORAGE

- ▶ All recordings and transcripts are stored in password-protected, encrypted storage. The storage location is documented in the Participant Registry.
- ▶ No participant recordings, transcripts, or contact information are stored on personal devices.
- ▶ No participant data is shared with third parties without explicit written consent.
- ▶ In the event of a data breach, the CA notifies affected participants within 72 hours and documents the breach and response in the Incident Log.

20 QUALITY ASSURANCE

Quality assurance in customer discovery is not about producing consistent outputs — it is about maintaining the conditions under which honest evidence can be collected. The QA processes in this section are designed to catch system failures, not to validate results.

20 SESSION QUALITY CHECKLIST

The CA reviews the following for each evidence-generating session before evidence extraction proceeds:

- ▶ Consent confirmed and documented
- ▶ Recording complete and named correctly
- ▶ Observation Form completed before recording review
- ▶ Session duration within acceptable range (45–75 minutes)

- Observation Form contains at least one contradiction and at least one moment of emphasis

Important: *An Observation Form that contains no contradictions and no moments of emphasis is a signal that the interviewer may not have been observing neutrally. The CA reviews these sessions with additional scrutiny before approving evidence extraction.*

20 CYCLE-END REVIEW

At the end of each discovery cycle, the CA conducts a cycle-end review covering: total sessions conducted, certification status of each interviewer, bias audit results, evidence registry size and distribution, and hypothesis status changes. The cycle-end review is documented and retained as part of the research record.

21 VERSION CONTROL

This Manual is a living document. Procedures evolve as LifeBook's discovery practice matures. Every change to this Manual is documented in the Version History below, including what changed, why it changed, and who approved the change.

Changes to this Manual that affect certification criteria, consent procedures, or data handling standards require review against the Interviewer Covenant before implementation. No procedural change may create a condition in which the Covenant's principles cannot be honoured.

VER SIO N	DAT E	SUMMARY OF CHANGES	APPROVED BY
1.0	202 6	Initial release	Tracy DesLaurier

22 EVIDENCE RETIREMENT

Evidence retirement is the process of formally closing evidence entries that are no longer active in hypothesis evaluation — because the hypothesis they supported has been closed, because the evidence has been superseded, or because a bias audit has determined the evidence was collected under compromised conditions.

Retired evidence is not deleted. It is marked as Retired in the Evidence Registry with a note on the reason for retirement and the date. Retired evidence may be reinstated if a new hypothesis makes it relevant.

RETIREMENT REASON	DESCRIPTION
Hypothesis Closed	The hypothesis this evidence supported has been confirmed, refuted, or retired. The evidence record is closed with it.
Superseded	More recent, higher-quality evidence has addressed the same question with greater clarity.
Bias Audit Finding	A bias audit determined this evidence was collected or coded under conditions that compromise its reliability.
Participant Withdrawal	The participant withdrew consent after the session. All evidence entries from that session are retired and the recording destroyed.

Participant withdrawal of consent is acted upon immediately. There is no minimum notice period, no exception for evidence already in the Registry, and no negotiation.

